

FAIRY QUEEN

Regarded as the world's oldest working steam locomotive, the *Fairy Queen* was built in January 1855 by Kitson, Thompson and Hewitson, a British locomotive manufacturing company in Leeds, UK. Supplied to the East Indian Railway (EIR), this 2-2-2 Well Tank BG Locomotive began work in August 1855 as Loco No. 22. It later came to be known as the EIR 22 before finally being named *Fairy Queen* in 1895.

The 8.5-m-long locomotive initially hauled mail trains in West Bengal on the 195-km-long Howrah–Raneegunge line. There are also records of it being used to haul trains of troops, from Howrah to Raneegunge, deployed to quell the uprisings during the Revolt of 1857. The locomotive was later dispatched to line construction duty in Bihar. After 1909, it was withdrawn from service and taken back to Calcutta and plinthed in Howrah till 1943.

It was exhibited at the National Rail Museum (NRM), New Delhi, in 1977. The 26-tonne veteran was revived and completely overhauled in 1996 in the Perambur Workshop of the Southern Railway. Several modifications were made to bring it back to life. Its driving wheels were reaxled, small compressors were put in, to make it an independently working air-braked unit, and a majority of its brass tubes were replaced with more modern fixtures. In July 1997, the *Fairy Queen* re-entered service as a part of a semi-regular heritage train – the Fairy Express – between Delhi and Alwar in Rajasthan. In July 2004, while parked at NRM, vandals stole a few of its parts – two brass handles and four copper pipes.

This “queen” was withdrawn from service in 2011 because of the need for specially made parts to keep the engine operational. In 2017, it was reintroduced into service as a part of the “steam express” programme of tourist trains.